

A small study of page layout

Two hundred readers read the same twelve documents twice, once in the original layout and once after it was reset with a single column, wider margins and fewer words per line. Every measure below compares the two readings.

Results

Table 1. Results of the study

Measure	Before	After	Change
Reading time per page	84 s	61 s	-27%
Readers who lost their place	41	16	-61%
Questions answered correctly	72%	88%	+16 pts
Pages reread at least once	2.9	1.4	-52%
Words per line	13	9	-31%
Satisfaction score	6.1	8.3	+2.2

The largest change was in readers who lost their place, which fell by more than half. Reading time per page fell by about a quarter. Satisfaction rose by two points on a ten point scale, the smallest change in relative terms and the one readers mentioned first when asked.

What the numbers do not say

The table reports averages. Behind the reading time of 61 seconds per page after the reset sits a wide spread: the fastest readers finished in half that, and the slowest took twice as long. The 88 percent of questions answered correctly hides that two of the twelve documents were answered no better than before.

A table is a good home for a number and a poor home for a caveat. When a passage is retrieved from this document, a row of the table carries its label and its values together only if the parser kept the row together. A parser that reads the cells as loose words leaves the number 61 with nothing to say what it measures.